

PLAYING BY EAR

Some things are easier
to play than they are to say.



CHRISTINA CARLSEN

IN OUR OWN WORDS — BOOK TWO

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EDUCATOR RESOURCE PACKET

By Christina Carlsen

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This guide was created to support educators, families, and reading groups exploring stories about neurodiversity, communication, and belonging. The In Our Own Words series is written for readers in grades 4–8.

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IN OUR OWN WORDS — BOOK TWO

Playing by Ear

TEACHER GUIDE

Free Educator Resource • Grades 4–8

Teacher Guide: *Playing by Ear*

In Our Own Words — Book Two

By Christina Carlsen

Prepared for Classroom Teachers, Grades 4–8

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1. Book Overview

Summary

Eleven-year-old Theo is, by all appearances, the easy one. While his twin brother Max is minimally verbal and autistic, and his younger sister Ellie is largely nonverbal and wears a harness in crowds, Theo moves through the world looking fine — funny, smooth, even charming. He has practiced this. He rehearses conversations in his bedroom before having them. He uses humor to save rooms. He keeps new people at exactly the right distance, because new people haven’t formed conclusions yet.

What Theo doesn’t say out loud — what this novel is quietly and persistently about — is that appearing easy and *being* easy are not the same thing. Theo has Childhood Apraxia of Speech (CAS), a motor speech disorder that requires real effort and strategy every single day. He is also autistic, masking so completely that even the people who love him most don’t see it. He carries the weight of being “the one everyone assumes is fine,” and he has been carrying it for a long time.

Playing by Ear follows Theo’s fifth-grade year: the Unified basketball season, a 5th grade dance, Sunday morning walks with his dad, an unexpected friendship with a girl named Eve, and a slow, hard, beautiful process of letting people in. By the time the last page turns, Theo hasn’t fixed anything — but he’s put down a few things he’d been carrying alone, and he’s figured out that belonging isn’t a destination you arrive at. It’s something you keep choosing.

Grade Level Recommendation

- **Primary audience:** Grades 4–6 (ages 9–12)
- **Extended audience:** Grades 7–8 for more complex thematic discussion around masking, identity, and disability
- **Read-aloud use:** Grades 3–5

Themes Overview

- Masking and the cost of appearing “easy”
- The invisible experience of the “easier” sibling
- Identity beneath performance
- Belonging vs. invisibility
- Friendship as witnessing
- Different kinds of love within a family
- Neurodiversity across a whole family
- Disability as visibility
- Communication differences
- Privilege within disability
- Upstander vs. bystander
- Grief, extended family, and the ache of unconditional love

Content Notes

Playing by Ear handles the following with care and age-appropriate nuance:

- **Disability:** Childhood Apraxia of Speech, autism, masking; presented with respect and insider perspective
- **Profanity:** One instance — Theo involuntarily says the f-word during a basketball game in front of the crowd (Ch. 9); it is presented as a consequence of his CAS and is a pivotal, treated-seriously moment, not played for laughs
- **Bullying/bystander moment:** A classmate (Alex) is targeted by older students in the courtyard; Theo witnesses it but does not fully intervene (Ch. 14); handled with reflection rather than resolution
- **Family complexity:** Parent mental health (Mom’s anxiety, OCD, ADHD; Dad’s parallel neurodivergence) is introduced matter-of-factly and compassionately in Chapter 11
- **Extended family estrangement:** Mom’s family largely withdrew when Max and Ellie’s needs became clear; the grief of this is present but not graphic
- **Grief:** Grandpa has left the family home; his absence is ached over; no death is depicted

None of these elements require teacher intervention before reading, but the content notes above may help you prepare for discussion.

2. About the Author

Christina Carlsen writes middle grade fiction about neurodivergent kids and the families who love them imperfectly and completely. *Playing by Ear* is the second book in the *In Our Own Words* series, which began with *The Boy Who Counts*, told from Max’s perspective. Carlsen’s writing is shaped by close knowledge of how neurodivergent children experience school, friendship, and family — and by an understanding that appearing fine is its own kind of work. Her books center the interior lives of characters who are often overlooked in children’s literature: the sibling who seems to be coping, the kid whose disability is invisible to most people in the room, the child who has learned to perform ease long before anyone told them they had to.

3. Connection to Book One

Playing by Ear is the second book in the *In Our Own Words* series. Book One, *The Boy Who Counts*, is told from Max’s perspective — the minimally verbal autistic twin who is usually the visible center of the family’s attention. Reading both books offers students a rich opportunity to compare first-person perspectives on the *same family*, the *same events*, and the *same relationships*. Students who have read Book One will recognize moments in Book Two from a completely different angle.

That said, ***Playing by Ear* is designed to stand alone.** Students who have not read Book One will find everything they need within this story. Theo introduces his family and his world with enough context that no prior reading is required.

For Classrooms Using Both Books

If you are teaching both books — together or in sequence — consider the following:

- **Compare perspectives:** How does Max appear in Book One vs. how Theo describes him in Book Two? How does reading one book change how you read the other?
- **The same family, two lenses:** Mom, Dad, Danny, Ellie, and the family dynamics appear in both. What do students notice about how each narrator describes the same parent? The same sibling?
- **Invisible vs. visible:** Max’s experience of the world is overtly different from neurotypical norms. Theo’s experience is different too — but he’s very good at hiding it. What does that say about who gets support and who gets overlooked?
- **Series arc:** Max says “I can do it” near the end of
- **Series arc:** Max says “I can do it” near the end of *Playing by Ear*. Students who read Book One may understand the weight of those words differently.

4. Before You Read

Background Information for Teachers

Before reading, teachers should feel confident in three areas: **Childhood Apraxia of Speech, autism and masking**, and the **“easier sibling” experience**. You do not need to be an expert. But having a working understanding of these concepts will help students engage more deeply with Theo’s experience.

Childhood Apraxia of Speech (CAS)

CAS is a motor speech disorder. Children with CAS know exactly what they want to say — the difficulty is in coordinating the movements required to say it. The brain has trouble sending consistent, accurate signals to the muscles needed for speech. This is *not* a language disorder (the language is intact) and *not* a cognitive disability. It is a coordination problem, and it is highly variable: a child with CAS may speak fluently in some contexts and struggle significantly in others, particularly under stress or when trying new or complex words.

Many children and adults with CAS develop compensatory strategies: short, practiced phrases; humor that buys time; avoiding words they know will trip them up; rehearsing scripts before conversations. Theo does all of this. He is not pretending — he is managing, the way he has been managing since early childhood.

What teachers should know: A student with CAS may appear fluent and socially capable while still working very hard behind the scenes. Do not assume ease indicates the absence of effort.

Autism and Masking

Autism is a neurological difference, not a disease or defect. Autistic people process sensory information, social cues, and emotions differently — not wrongly. The autistic spectrum is genuinely a spectrum: some autistic people are minimally verbal (like Max in this series); others speak fluently and move through neurotypical social environments with apparent ease (like Theo).

Masking is the conscious or unconscious suppression of natural autistic behaviors in order to appear neurotypical. It can include: scripting conversations in advance, mirroring others' body language, suppressing stimming, forcing eye contact, and monitoring one's own speech and behavior continuously. Masking takes enormous energy. Over time, it leads to exhaustion, anxiety, and — critically — a loss of self. Many autistic people, especially those who mask well, never receive a diagnosis.

Theo is not labeled autistic in the text (reflecting the real experience of many masked autistic children who go undiagnosed). His behaviors are described from the inside, in his own words. The author's note at the end of the book confirms that Theo is autistic, but Carlsen has deliberately left the label out of the story itself — because for Theo, the label doesn't exist yet. What exists is the experience.

What teachers should know: There may be students in your classroom who recognize themselves in Theo without knowing why. Be thoughtful when discussing masking.

The “Easier Sibling” Experience

Families with a child who has high visible support needs often have another child (or children) who is perceived as “the easy one.” That child may genuinely be less impacted — or they may have learned, quite young, that the way to get through the day is to need less. The “easier” sibling often carries invisible emotional weight: love for a sibling alongside grief or frustration, the wish for more parental attention alongside guilt about that wish, the effort of performing “fine” because the family system depends on it.

This is not a story about a child being neglected. Theo's parents love him deeply and show up for him. But the structural reality of his family's needs means that Theo has learned to take up less space — and this novel is about what it costs him, and what it looks like when he slowly, carefully begins to take up more.

Vocabulary to Pre-Teach

These terms appear in the text or are central to its themes. Pre-teaching them will help students engage more fully.

Term	Definition
Apraxia	Difficulty coordinating the movements required for a task (in Theo's case, speech)
CAS	Childhood Apraxia of Speech; a motor speech disorder
Masking	Hiding or suppressing natural behaviors to appear more neurotypical
Neurodivergent	Having a brain that processes information differently from what is considered "typical"
AAC	Augmentative and Alternative Communication; tools (including apps) that help nonverbal or minimally verbal people communicate
Unified	Unified Sports; a Special Olympics program that integrates athletes with and without intellectual disabilities on the same team
Stimming	Self-stimulatory behavior (repetitive movements or sounds) that helps regulate sensory or emotional experience
Script	In the context of social communication: a prepared, practiced response or phrase
Word retrieval	The ability to find the right word when you need it; Theo struggles with this under pressure
Visible	Used in the book to describe moments when a family member's disability is noticeable to others in a public space

Pre-Reading Discussion Prompts

Use these to activate prior knowledge and build a container for the book's themes before students begin reading.

- Have you ever practiced something you were going to say before you said it? What was the situation? How did it feel?
- What does it mean to "fit in"? Is fitting in the same thing as belonging?
- If you have a sibling (or a close family member), do you think other people see that person the way you see them? What might they be missing?
- Have you ever felt invisible even when you were surrounded by people? What was that like?
- What do you think it means to be a good friend to someone who is going through something hard? Is there a difference between helping and fixing?

- What do you already know about speech differences or autism? What would you want to know more about?

5. Character Guide

Theo

Eleven years old. The narrator of *Playing by Ear* and the “easier twin.” Theo has Childhood Apraxia of Speech (CAS) and is autistic, though he has not been diagnosed with autism in the story — he masks too well. To the outside world, Theo appears confident, funny, and socially fluid. Inside, he rehearses conversations before having them, struggles with word retrieval under pressure, and carries the enormous emotional weight of being the one everyone assumes is fine. He plays drums on Saturdays in the garage and teaches himself piano by ear on a secondhand keyboard. He loves “new people” because new people arrive without conclusions about who he is. The book is the story of Theo slowly, carefully, beginning to let people past the “new person” stage.

What to watch for: The gap between how Theo appears to others and who Theo actually is. Also: the moments when someone lets him stop performing.

Max

Theo’s twin brother. Minimally verbal and autistic. In this book, Max is seen entirely through Theo’s eyes — which means we see him with love, frustration, pride, and sometimes exhaustion, all at once. Max sorts books by color. Max teaches Theo how to breathe — in, hold, out. By the end of the book, Max says “I can do it.” Max matters enormously to Theo, and Theo’s complicated feelings about Max’s visibility are at the center of the novel’s emotional journey.

What to watch for: The reversal — when Max becomes the teacher and Theo becomes the one learning to breathe.

Danny

Theo’s younger brother, age 7. Danny is a force of uncomplicated joy. He asks questions about everything. He makes friends instantly — at the Unified basketball practice, at the dance. He wears headphones. He counts ceiling tiles. He doesn’t see the world as a problem to be managed. He is, in many ways, the book’s emotional counterweight: what it looks like to be fully yourself without apology.

What to watch for: Danny’s question-asking as its own form of curiosity and love.

Ellie

Theo's younger sister, age 8. Autistic and largely nonverbal, Ellie wears a harness in crowds and hums a three-note song that Theo believes came from their late grandfather. Ellie is one of the main sources of Theo's complicated feelings about family visibility — she is noticeable in public in ways he finds hard to be near. He loves her. He also finds certain moments difficult. Both things are true, and the novel does not punish him for that.

What to watch for: How Ellie's presence both connects to and complicates Theo's story. She is not a mirror of Theo but a separate person.

Mom

Mom has anxiety, OCD, and ADHD — a revelation she shares with Theo in Chapter 11. She practices conversations before phone calls. She works from home to manage. She was “the good one” in her own family of origin, and she understands being the one who holds things together. She loves fiercely and talks openly about her children to new people — something Theo finds both useful and embarrassing. She fights for Max. She shows up for Theo in ways he doesn't always recognize until later.

What to watch for: The ways she communicates with Theo (not just about him), and the moments her effort breaks through.

Dad

Also neurodivergent (a “more careful and controlled version,” per Mom). Dad's love language is solving — he moves through the family's needs like a conveyor belt, efficient and present. He shows affection through one solid hand on the back, through walking further on Sunday mornings, through saying “Love you, bud.” He plays Skyrim. He does not always recognize the missed passes, but he is there, and the scene where Theo runs across the couch to hug him for real is one of the book's quietest emotional climaxes.

What to watch for: The parallel between Theo's kind of communication and his father's.

Jay

Theo's school aide. Twenty-three years old, he has known Theo since summer school and understands how Theo's brain works. He doesn't hover. He is the perfect balance of present and invisible — which, for Theo, is everything. There is a funny moment at the dance when Theo discovers Jay's mother is the vice principal.

What to watch for: What Jay does and doesn't do, and why each choice matters to Theo.

Ms. Patrice

Theo's speech therapist since 2nd grade. Warm, reliable, brings good snacks. She ambushes Theo in the main hallway on the first day of school — kindly, but in front of forty fifth graders — which is embarrassing. Their whiteboard sessions are some of the most emotionally honest scenes in the book. She is the first person to name what Theo is carrying: “That's a lot to carry. You carried it anyway.”

What to watch for: The whiteboard sessions as a space where Theo can say what he can't say out loud.

Eve

Theo's friend and, increasingly, his emotional anchor. Eve is funny, perceptive, and direct without being forceful. She sits next to Theo on the hallway steps at the basketball game without asking, holds his hand, and says "me too" instead of "you'll be fine." She types to him in art class. She tells him his family is her favorite. She gives him infinity spinning rings at the dance. She is the friend Theo didn't know he needed — the one who witnesses him without needing him to perform.

What to watch for: The "without asking" moments — when Eve acts without requiring Theo to perform gratitude or explain himself.

Marcus

A classmate from Theo's street. Low-key, reliable, uncomplicated. He names Theo by something real ("You're the kid with the drums") and then turns back to his desk — no big deal. At the end of the book, he deflects Brett's reference to the f-word incident with a perfectly timed piece of humor. He says "Good year" at the dance. He is not Theo's best friend, but he is the kind of person you can count on to be exactly where they said they'd be.

What to watch for: What Marcus's quiet reliability means to a person who is always tracking whether people are safe.

Coach Daniels

Unified basketball coach. Calm, low-pressure, adjusts on the fly. His guidance to Theo after the f-word incident — "You take the shot. That's your job" — becomes one of the novel's central pieces of wisdom.

What to watch for: The way Coach responds to the incident — what he doesn't make it into.

Mr. Callahan

Fifth grade homeroom teacher. A "talking to, not at" teacher. Fair, consistent, mentions Unified basketball twice. The kind of teacher who notices things without making them a production.

What to watch for: What "talking to, not at" looks like in practice.

Alex

A former friend who laughed at Theo during the playground incident in 2nd grade. Now a classmate again. Gets targeted by older kids in the courtyard in Chapter 14. Theo says "No" when Alex assumes he's finding it funny — but doesn't intervene more. Theo thinks about what he'd do differently next time. Alex is not a villain and not fully redeemed; he's a person with a complicated history who is also capable of being hurt.

What to watch for: How Theo's past with Alex shapes what he can and can't do in the courtyard moment.

Aunt Nancy

Mom's aunt. Comes from far away for the Unified basketball game. Smaller than Theo remembered. She says, "I don't know how you do it" — well-meaning but complicated to receive. Her presence brings the weight of extended family absence and the warmth of someone who made the effort to show up.

What to watch for: What Aunt Nancy's words reveal about what people assume about this family.

Grandpa

Never present in the novel's timeline — he lived with the family for five years, then left when it became too much. But his presence is felt. He sang in a low voice to Ellie. Theo believes Ellie's three-note hum came from him. He made individual time for each child. He was the kind of person who stayed as long as he could, and his leaving is a quiet, real grief.

What to watch for: How Grandpa's absence is felt through what remains — especially Ellie's hum.

6. Chapter-by-Chapter Discussion Questions

Questions are grouped by chapter or cluster. Not every chapter has a separate section — some are grouped thematically. Choose what fits your classroom's pace and focus.

Prologue: "The Easier One"

- Theo says being called "the easier twin" feels like a compliment — until you realize "easy and invisible are cousins." What do you think he means? Do you agree?
- Before you've read a single chapter, what questions do you already have about Theo?

Chapters 1–2: First Day / New People

- Why does Theo love "new people"? What does he mean when he says they "arrive without conclusions"?
- Theo rehearses what he's going to say before he says it. Why might someone do that? Does it remind you of anything you've experienced?
- The playground incident ends with Theo's mom announcing his speech delay to 50 people. How do you think Theo felt in that moment? How does that moment still affect him years later?
- Theo says he hasn't been back to that playground in four years. What does that tell us about how our experiences shape our behavior?

Chapter 3: The Secondhand Keyboard

- Theo practices his lunch table opening lines alone in his room. His mom catches him talking to the wall. He says it's not weird. Do you think it's weird? Why or why not?
- Theo taught himself to play the keyboard "by ear" — by listening and imitating without sheet music. What do you think that says about how he learns? How do you learn best?

- Why do you think music is important to Theo? What does it let him do that everyday conversation doesn't?

Chapters 4–5: Danny's Baseball Game / Unified Basketball

- Theo watches his mom “do the thing” — explain her family to new people at Danny's baseball game. He finds it both helpful and embarrassing. Have you ever felt that way about something a family member said or did in public?
- At Unified basketball practice, nobody looks at Danny's headphones. Theo notices this. What does it mean to be in a space where your differences don't attract attention?
- Danny counts the ceiling tiles. Theo counted them too. What do you think this small detail means?

Chapter 6: “Two Worlds” — The Basketball Game

- When Ellie arrives in the wrong clothes (accident on the van), Theo feels something complicated. What is he feeling? Is there more than one feeling at once?
- Theo walks out to the hallway and sits on the steps. Eve sits next to him without asking. Why is the “without asking” important?
- Eve holds Theo's hand. They walk back in together. The whole gym claps. How do you think Theo feels about that? Is the clapping a good thing?
- What does it mean to walk back into a hard situation instead of leaving?

Chapter 7: “The Conveyor Belt”

- Theo describes his dad as an “assembly line” — moving efficiently through each child's needs. Is this a criticism or just an observation?
- Mom tells Theo that Dad shows love by solving things. How many different ways can people show love? What are some ways that might be easy to miss?
- At the end of the chapter, Theo hugs his dad for real. What changed? What made that possible?

Chapter 8: “Easy Kids”

- The family's plan for the Mario movie falls apart twice. Theo asks if just he and Danny could go. Mom says “flexibility.” Why does Theo sit with that word?
- Theo says Tuesday — when he, Mom, and Danny finally go — is actually good. What made it good?
- When they get home, Theo tells Dad, “You should have come too.” What does that tell us about how Theo is changing?

Chapter 9: “Rival Town”

- Theo involuntarily says the f-word when he misses a shot. He runs to the hallway. What do you think happened in his brain in that moment?
- Aunt Nancy says, “I don't know how you do it.” Mom answers: “Do what.” What do you think Mom's response means? Is it a rebuke, a genuine question, or something else?

- Coach says: “You take the shot. That’s your job.” What do you think he means by that? Does it apply to things other than basketball?
- Mom sings “Somewhere Over the Rainbow” on the drive home. Why does that moment matter?

Chapters 10–11: “Everybody Saw” / Mom’s Reveal

- Monday after the game, Theo doesn’t want to go to school. What is he afraid of?
- Mom tells Theo she has anxiety, OCD, and ADHD. She practiced conversations before calls. She works from home to manage. How does learning this change the way you see Mom? How does it change the way you see Theo?
- Mom says: “We didn’t have a map. You do.” What map does Theo have that his parents didn’t?
- Ms. Patrice says: “Belonging isn’t a place you find once. It’s something you keep choosing.” What do you think that means? Do you agree?
- Marcus’s response to Brett — deflecting the f-word reference with a joke — is a small moment. Why is it important?

Chapter 13: “Max”

- Theo and Max sort books together in silence. What kind of communication is happening between them even without words?
- Max teaches Theo to breathe — in, hold, out. Why is it significant that Max is the one doing the teaching here?
- Max signs “Happy.” Max says “Good.” What do those two words mean, given everything we know about Max?

Chapter 14: “Alex”

- Theo sees Alex getting targeted. He says “No” when Alex assumes he’s laughing. He doesn’t intervene more. Was that enough? What would have been harder?
- Theo thinks about what he’d do next time. Is that meaningful, even if nothing changed this time?
- How do you decide when to step in and when stepping in might make things worse?

Chapter 15: “Eve’s Hair”

- Theo tells Eve she looks “grown up” when someone has said her hair looks weird. Why is that a good response? What makes it different from “You look fine” or “I think it looks great”?
- Theo types: *“I get embarrassed sometimes. When they’re visible. And then I feel bad about feeling embarrassed because I love them. And I don’t know what to do with both of those things at the same time.”* Have you ever felt two contradictory things at the same time about someone you love?
- Eve types back that Theo’s family accepts everyone exactly as they are, and that’s rare. How does Theo receive that?

Chapters 16–17: “Further” / The Dance

- Dad asks Theo if he wants to go “further” on their walk. They do. What is that walk really about?
- Theo does the orange justice dance “fully committed.” What changed for him to be able to do that?
- Eve gives Theo infinity spinning rings. Marcus says “Good year.” How do these small gestures land after everything we’ve read?

Chapter 18 and Epilogue

- Max says “I can do it” — and then says it better each time. Why does that matter so much to Theo?
- The final line: *“I wanted this family, exactly as it was, with a little more room for all of himself in it.”* What does “a little more room for all of himself” mean? What room has Theo made by the end of this book?
- The epilogue ends with “Maybe next week” — Theo thinking about teaching Max drums. What does that “maybe” feel like? Hopeful? Uncertain? Both?

7. Major Themes

Theme 1: Masking and the Cost of Appearing “Easy”

“The thing about being ‘the easier twin’ is everybody acts like it’s a compliment. Until you realize easy and invisible are cousins.”

Masking is the central tension of this book. Theo is excellent at appearing fine — and the novel asks us to sit with how much that costs him. He rehearses scripts. He monitors himself constantly. He uses humor as a deflection tool. He keeps people at the “new person” distance where they can’t see behind the performance. He is eleven years old and he has been doing this for years.

The novel is not a story about Theo stopping. It is a story about Theo, very slowly, beginning to set some of it down — the hug with Dad, the hand-hold with Eve, the orange justice dance. Each of these moments is an act of courage disguised as something small.

Discussion questions:

- Why might a person mask their true feelings or struggles? What might they be afraid of?
- Is there a difference between being polite and performing who you are? Where is the line?
- Theo says “funny kids are usually trying to save the room.” What do you think he means?
- What are some costs of always appearing fine?

Theme 2: The “Easier Sibling” Experience

“Easy and invisible are cousins.”

Theo is the sibling who doesn’t need as much. Or rather, he has learned not to need as much. The book takes this experience — which is underrepresented in literature and in life — and treats it with full seriousness. Theo’s love for his family is real and unconditional. So is his exhaustion, his wish for more room, his complicated feelings when his family is visible in public.

Discussion questions:

- Is it fair to expect the “easier” child to need less? Why or why not?
- Can you love someone and also find some things about them hard? What do you do with both feelings?
- What would it look like for a family to make more room for the child who seems to be doing fine?

Theme 3: Belonging vs. Invisibility

“If you kept people at the distance where they were still new, you never actually had them.”

Theo is good at fitting in. He has practiced it. But fitting in is not the same as belonging — and this distinction is at the heart of his friendship with Eve and his relationship with Marcus. Belonging requires being seen, which requires letting someone past the “new person” stage, which requires risk.

Discussion questions:

- What is the difference between fitting in and belonging?
- What would you need to feel safe enough to let someone see you more fully?
- Ms. Patrice says: *“Belonging isn’t a place you find once. It’s something you keep choosing.”* What do you think that means in practice?

Theme 4: Friendship as Witnessing

“Me too.” — Eve, about being nervous

The friends who matter most to Theo are not the ones who fix things. They are the ones who stay. Eve sits next to him on the hallway steps without asking. She doesn’t tell him he’ll be fine. She says “me too.” Marcus doesn’t make the f-word incident a big deal — he deflects it with humor and moves on. Jay is present without hovering.

Discussion questions:

- What is the difference between a friend who tries to fix something and a friend who witnesses it?
- Think of a time you wanted someone to just be there, not say anything helpful. What made that moment hard?
- How did Eve’s “me too” help Theo more than “you’ll be fine” would have?

Theme 5: Neurodiversity Across a Family

“We didn’t have a map. You do.” — Mom

By the end of Chapter 11, we understand that Theo’s entire immediate family is neurodivergent, each in a different way. Max is autistic and minimally verbal. Ellie is autistic and largely nonverbal. Danny has sensory needs. Mom has anxiety, OCD, and ADHD. Dad has his own version of neurodivergence. Theo has CAS and is autistic. The family is not unusual because of Max — they are a neurodivergent family, full stop.

This reframe is important. It moves the story away from “one disabled kid in an otherwise typical family” and toward something truer and more complex: a family in which everyone navigates the world differently, everyone has their strategies, and the map that Mom and Dad had to figure out without guidance is the map they’re now handing to their kids.

Discussion questions:

- How does learning that Mom and Dad are neurodivergent change your understanding of them as parents?
- What does it mean to give your children a “map” you didn’t have yourself?
- Why might it matter for Theo to know that his parents navigate things similarly to how he does?

Theme 6: Communication Differences

“I can do it.” — Max, at the end

Communication in this novel takes many forms: rehearsed scripts, AAC apps, whiteboard sessions, typing on tablets, one hand on the back, a hum of three notes, silence while sorting books. Carlsen insists on the full range — and on the reality that not all communication is verbal, not all verbal communication is easy, and the forms of communication that matter most are sometimes the quietest.

Discussion questions:

- How many forms of communication appear in this novel? Which feel most powerful?
- Max and Theo sort books together in silence and something real happens between them. What is it?
- What do you communicate with people without using words?

Theme 7: Privilege Within Disability

“New people arrived without conclusions.”

Theo’s CAS is invisible to people who don’t know him. His autism is invisible because he masks it. His access to appearing typical gives him something Max doesn’t have — the ability to move through the world without constant visibility. The novel doesn’t frame this as simply good or bad. It is what it is, and it costs Theo something. But it is worth examining.

Discussion questions:

- What advantages does Theo have in the world that Max doesn’t?
- Are there costs to those advantages? What are they?
- What does it feel like to be visible? What does it feel like to be invisible? Can both feel like problems?

8. Activity Ideas

Activity 1: “New People” Journaling (ELA/SEL)

Theo loves new people because they arrive without conclusions. He has a version of himself he shows to new people before they form opinions.

Prompt: Write about a version of yourself that you show to new people. Is it different from the version your close friends see? Is it different from how you feel inside? Which version feels most true, and why?

Differentiation: Students may draw, diagram, or use a Venn circle instead of writing.

Activity 2: The Cereal Aisle — Perspective Stories (ELA)

In Chapter 2, Theo uses the “cereal aisle metaphor” — the idea that walking into a grocery store aisle and being seen as just another shopper feels different from being seen as the kid with the speech thing.

Prompt: Write a short first-person story from the perspective of a character navigating a public moment where they feel very visible. Then write the same moment from the perspective of a bystander who has no idea what the other person is experiencing. Share and discuss: what did you assume? What did you miss?

Activity 3: Character Mapping — How People Show Love (SEL/ELA)

The novel shows many different love languages and communication styles. Mom shows love through adventure, openness, and showing up. Dad shows love by solving. Eve shows love by witnessing. Jay shows love by not hovering.

Prompt: Create a character map for three characters in the novel. For each, describe: How do they show love or care? What might someone miss if they didn’t know how to read it? Is there a character whose way of showing love is easiest to see? Hardest? Then turn the lens on your own life: how do people in your family show care, and how do you know when you’re getting it?

Activity 4: Whiteboard Session (SEL/Writing)

In Ms. Patrice’s sessions, Theo uses a whiteboard to write what he can’t easily say. At one point, he writes: “*My family. Visible. Tired of managing. Scared of what people see.*”

Prompt: Give students a “whiteboard moment.” They can write or draw: something they carry that’s hard to say out loud, a feeling they have about their family, or anything they’d write if they knew no one was judging. This can be private (students keep it) or shared only by choice.

Note: Make this genuinely private if you do it. Students need to trust that this will not be read or graded.

Activity 5: Soundscape — Theo’s World (Music/SEL)

Theo plays drums and teaches himself piano by ear. Sound and music are important to his interior life.

Prompt: Students choose or create a piece of music (using found sounds, classroom instruments, or a playlist) that represents a character from the novel — or a moment in the novel. They explain their choices: what does the tempo represent? The dynamics? The instrumentation? Is there silence? Why?

Extension: Create a playlist for Theo, from the first day of school to the epilogue. How does the music change?

Activity 6: “Belonging Isn’t a Place” — Visual Art (Art/SEL)

Ms. Patrice says: “*Belonging isn’t a place you find once. It’s something you keep choosing.*”

Prompt: Create a visual response to this idea. What does belonging look like? What does choosing it look like? This can be abstract, representational, collage, or mixed media. Students write a brief artist’s statement explaining what they were trying to capture.

Activity 7: Upstander Research and Role-Play (Social Studies/SEL)

Chapter 14 presents the hardest kind of upstander moment: when you see something wrong, you don’t act as much as you wish you had, and then you think about what you’d do next time.

- Part 1: Research upstander vs. bystander behavior. What makes it hard to intervene? What are different ways to intervene (direct, indirect, support the target after, report to an adult)?
- Part 2: Role-play 2–3 scenarios in small groups. Debrief: What made it hard? What made it easier? What would you do with 10 more seconds to think?
- Part 3: Theo thinks about what he’d do next time. Write a brief “next time” plan for a situation where you know you could do more.

Activity 8: Unified Sports Research Project (Social Studies/PE)

Unified basketball plays a central role in the novel. The book describes a space where the usual social rules feel different.

Prompt: Research the Special Olympics Unified Sports program. What is its history? How does it work? What is the philosophy behind it? Is there a Unified program at your school or in your district? If not, what would it take to start one? Students can present their research as a poster, a short report, a slide presentation, or a pitch to the school administration.

Activity 9: Communication Audit (ELA/Social Science)

The novel contains at least eight distinct forms of communication: spoken conversation, rehearsed scripts, AAC apps, whiteboard writing, typing on tablets, sign language, physical touch (hand on back, hand-hold), and music/humming.

Prompt: Track every form of communication that appears in the novel over a given set of chapters. Create a “communication chart” that catalogs who uses each form, when, and what gets communicated. Then discuss: Which forms are most valued in schools? Which are less visible? What might schools do differently to recognize more forms as legitimate?

Activity 10: Letter to Theo (ELA/SEL)

At the end of the novel, Theo has made some room for more of himself — but not all of it. He is still working on it.

Prompt: Write a letter to Theo. You might: tell him what you noticed about him that he can't see himself; ask him a question; tell him something you recognized; offer him something you wish someone had offered you. These can be shared in pairs or kept private.

9. Social-Emotional Learning Connections

Self-Awareness

Theo becomes more self-aware over the course of the novel — not in a tidy way, but in the way it actually happens: slowly, in moments, often triggered by someone else's honesty. The whiteboard session with Ms. Patrice, Mom's reveal in Chapter 11, typing with Eve in art class — these are all moments where Theo sees himself a little more clearly.

Key question: *What helps you see yourself more clearly? What gets in the way?*

Self-Management

Theo manages himself constantly — and the novel does something unusual by showing the cost of that. He is an expert at emotional regulation that comes at enormous energy expense. The book invites discussion about the difference between healthy self-management and the kind that becomes suppression.

Key question: *Is there a difference between managing your feelings and hiding them? Where does one become the other?*

Social Awareness

Theo is highly attuned to others — because he has to be, because his safety in social situations has always depended on it. But this attunement is also a burden. The novel invites students to think about what social awareness costs and who is expected to carry it.

Key question: *Who in your school has to work hardest to fit in? Do you think they find that hard or easy?*

Relationship Skills

Eve, Marcus, and Jay each model a different form of relational skill: witnessing, reliability, and appropriate presence. The novel argues, quietly but firmly, that the best friends are not the ones who fix things — they are the ones who stay.

Key question: *Think of a friendship that made you feel truly seen. What did that person do (or not do) that made it feel that way?*

Responsible Decision-Making

Chapter 14 (Alex in the courtyard) is the most direct encounter with responsible decision-making in the novel. Theo acts partially and reflects afterward. The book doesn't punish him — but it also doesn't let him off the hook.

Key question: *What does it mean to do more? What gets in the way of doing more than the minimum?*

10. Disability Awareness Connections

Childhood Apraxia of Speech (CAS)

Theo's CAS is present throughout the novel in the way he navigates it, not in clinical descriptions. Students should understand:

- CAS is a motor speech disorder, not a language or intellectual disability
- The person with CAS knows what they want to say; the difficulty is in the physical coordination
- Children with CAS often develop workarounds: humor, short sentences, practiced phrases, avoidance of hard-to-say words
- These strategies can look like fluency to outsiders — which is part of why Theo's experience is invisible

In the classroom: If you have students with speech differences, this book normalizes the experience of practicing language without framing it as strange or pitiable. It also gives neurotypical students a window into an experience they may have misunderstood.

Autism and Masking

Theo is autistic. He is not diagnosed in the story, and this is intentional — it reflects the reality of many masked autistic people, especially those who present as socially capable. His behaviors include:

- Scripting conversations in advance
- Counting ceiling tiles
- Being highly attuned to social cues (as a survival strategy, not naturally)
- Exhaustion after social performance
- Preferring routine, predictable spaces
- Loving people who don't require him to perform

Critical discussion: The novel shows that autism looks very different in different people. Max and Theo are both autistic. What does each of them struggle with? What does each of them do well? What assumptions do other characters make about each of them?

Neurodiversity as a Family Experience

By Chapter 11, we understand that Theo’s entire immediate family is neurodivergent. This is an underrepresented perspective in children’s literature. The usual frame is: one disabled child + a neurotypical family doing their best. *Playing by Ear* rejects that frame and offers something truer: a whole family navigating the world differently, each in their own way.

Discussion: What changes when we understand that Theo’s parents are also navigating their own neurological differences? What does it mean to parent neurodivergent children when you are neurodivergent yourself?

AAC and Communication Diversity

Ellie uses an AAC app. Max communicates through action, sign, and occasional words. Theo uses practiced scripts. The novel presents a full spectrum of communication and asks readers to recognize that all of these are legitimate.

Activity connection: See Activity 9 (Communication Audit) for a structured way to explore this.

Unified Sports

Unified basketball is a Special Olympics program that integrates athletes with and without intellectual disabilities. The novel portrays it as a genuinely different kind of space — one where Danny’s headphones are unremarkable, where Max walking onto the court is handled calmly, where the social rules feel less pointed.

Resource: Special Olympics Unified Sports: www.specialolympics.org/our-work/unified-sports

11. The “Easy One” Discussion

This section is for classroom teachers who want to spend dedicated time on the novel’s central and most underexplored theme: what it means to be the child (or sibling, or student) who everyone assumes is fine.

Opening the Conversation

Begin not with the book, but with a wider question:

Have you ever felt invisible even when you were in a room full of people who care about you? What was that like?

Let students respond in writing or in a brief think-pair-share before opening to a full class discussion. The goal is not to identify who in the room is the “easy one” — it is to establish that invisibility is a genuine experience, not a complaint about someone else’s needs.

Key Ideas to Discuss

- **The difference between appearing fine and being fine.** Theo appears fine. He is funny, social, and adaptive. He is also rehearsing conversations in his room, struggling with word retrieval, carrying emotional weight he doesn’t have language for. Appearing fine is a skill. Being fine is a different thing.

- **The cost of being needed less.** When one child in a family (or one student in a classroom) has high visible support needs, the children who seem to need less often learn to ask for less. This is not a character flaw. It is a reasonable adaptation. But it has costs: the child who learns to ask for less may eventually stop knowing what they need.
- **Both things can be true.** Theo loves his family. He also sometimes wishes he could have more of it for himself. Both things are true, and the novel holds both without punishing either. Students who are navigating complex family situations often feel that having complicated feelings means they are a bad person. The novel offers a corrective: complicated feelings are just honest.
- **The “easy” child is seen by the narrative.** One of the most powerful things *Playing by Ear* does is simply this: it tells Theo’s story. Not Max’s. Theo’s. It insists that Theo’s interior life is interesting, complicated, and worth following. Students who have felt like the background character in their own families may find something genuinely important in that.

Discussion Prompts

- Have you ever felt like you were supposed to be “the easy one” in a group — at home, at school, on a team? What was expected of you?
- What is the difference between being low-maintenance and being invisible?
- Why do you think Carlsen chose to write this book about Theo, rather than another book about Max?
- Is there someone in your life — a sibling, a classmate, a friend — who always seems to be fine? What do you actually know about what they’re carrying?

A Note on Safety

Some students in your classroom may be living this experience. Be thoughtful. You do not need to identify or single anyone out. The discussion is most useful when it is wide enough to let students recognize themselves privately, without being asked to claim it publicly. If a student does share something significant, follow your school’s standard protocols for student support and follow-up.

12. Extension Reading and Resources

Books for Students (Similar Themes)

Middle Grade / Upper Elementary:

- *The Many Meanings of Smeara Nox* — for readers interested in communication differences and the inner life behind speech
- *Counting by 7s* by Holly Goldberg Sloan — outsider perception vs. interior life; found family
- *Fish in a Tree* by Lynda Mullaly Hunt — a child whose learning difference goes undetected; the exhaustion of appearing fine
- *Wonder* by R.J. Palacio — disability and belonging; multiple perspectives

- *El Deafo* by Cece Bell — graphic memoir; navigating disability, friendship, and visibility
- *Front Desk* by Kelly Yang — navigating multiple pressures while appearing capable and smooth
- *The Boy Who Counts* (Book One of *In Our Own Words*) by Christina Carlsen — Max’s perspective; same family, same world

Picture Books (for read-aloud, or younger sibling connections):

- *My Brother Charlie* by Holly Robinson Peete — a sibling’s perspective on having a brother with autism
- *The Invisible String* by Patrice Karst — connection across distance and difference

Books for Teachers

- *NeuroTribes* by Steve Silberman — the history and science of autism; highly readable
- *Unmasking Autism* by Devon Price — written for autistic adults, but valuable for educators understanding masked autism
- *The Dyslexic Advantage* by Brock and Fennete Eide — the flip side of learning differences; strength-based framing
- *It’s Kind of a Funny Story* by Ned Vizzini (for older readers in grades 7–8 extension) — mental health, performance, the cost of appearing fine

Organizations and Resources

- **Apraxia Kids** (apraxia-kids.org) — comprehensive resource on Childhood Apraxia of Speech; includes family and educator guides
- **Autism Society of America** (autism-society.org) — broad resources on autism across the lifespan
- **ASHA (American Speech-Language-Hearing Association)** (asha.org) — professional information on CAS; parent-friendly pages available
- **Special Olympics Unified Sports** (specialolympics.org/our-work/unified-sports) — program information, how to start a chapter
- **Understood.org** — practical guides for parents and teachers on learning and thinking differences, including CAS, ADHD, and autism; highly accessible
- **Autistic Self Advocacy Network (ASAN)** (autisticadvocacy.org) — autism resources written by autistic people; includes “Welcome to the Autistic Community” guide

13. Assessment Ideas

Assessment for this novel should reflect its themes. A book about the cost of performing for others should not demand only one kind of performance from readers. The options below range across written, visual, oral, and creative modes.

Written Options

Literary Analysis Essay

Choose one theme from the novel and trace how it develops across at least three chapters. Use specific quotes and scenes as evidence. Possible topics:

- How does Theo change over the course of the novel?
- What is the difference between fitting in and belonging in this book?
- How does the novel show that love takes many different forms?

Character Study

Choose a secondary character (Eve, Marcus, Jay, Mom, Dad, or Grandpa — who never appears but is felt throughout). Write a character study explaining what this character contributes to the novel and what they represent for Theo's growth.

Personal Response Essay

Which moment or scene in the novel felt most true to your own experience? Explain the connection — what it was, why it resonated, and what you think the author understood about that experience.

Analytical Paragraph — Short Form

For students not yet ready for a full essay: Choose one quote from the novel. Explain what it means, what moment in the story it connects to, and why it matters to the book's main idea.

Visual and Creative Options

Illustrated Chapter Map

Create a visual map of Theo's emotional journey across the novel. This could be a timeline, a graph, a road/path illustration, or an abstract visual representation. Include at least six specific moments from the novel, with brief captions explaining why each moment matters.

Book Jacket Design

Design a new book jacket for *Playing by Ear*. The front must suggest the book's central theme without giving away the plot. Include back cover copy and a brief author bio. Write a designer's note explaining your visual choices.

Playlist + Liner Notes

Create a playlist for Theo, from the first day of school to the epilogue. Choose 8–12 songs. Write liner notes for each song: why you chose it, what moment in the novel it connects to, and what it captures about Theo’s experience.

Oral and Performance Options

Socratic Seminar

Use the following overarching question as a Socratic seminar prompt:

“Belonging isn’t a place you find once. It’s something you keep choosing.” What does this mean — for Theo, for other characters in the novel, and for you?

Students prepare by identifying at least three specific passages from the book that connect to this question. Assessment is based on quality of contributions, use of text evidence, and engagement with others’ ideas.

Character Interview

In pairs or small groups: one student plays a character from the novel; others ask interview questions. The character must answer in character, drawing on what we know from the book. Students may also write out a “pre-interview preparation” document beforehand.

Book Talk

Students deliver a 3–5 minute book talk, as if recommending (or not recommending) the novel to a peer. They must include: a brief summary, the most important theme in their view, a quote that stuck with them, and a connection to their own life or another book they’ve read.

Differentiated / Low-Stakes Options

Response Journal

Keep a running journal throughout reading. At the end of each reading session, respond to one prompt: a question you have, a connection you made, a moment that felt true, a moment that felt wrong, or a quote you want to hold onto. Assessed for engagement and honest reflection, not correctness.

Exit Conversations

For students for whom written assessment is not accessible or appropriate: a brief 5–7 minute one-on-one or small-group conversation using three to four discussion questions from the chapter guide. Assess for evidence of reading comprehension and engagement with ideas.

14. A Note for Teachers

This book is about masking. And masking is not just something that happens in fiction.

There are students in your classroom right now who are working very hard to appear fine. Some of them have diagnoses. Some do not. Some are managing speech differences. Some are managing attention, sensory experience, anxiety, family stress, or the particular exhaustion of being the child everyone assumes is coping. Many of them are eleven years old and they have been doing this for years.

Teaching *Playing by Ear* is a gift you can give to those students — not because the book will solve anything, but because it says, in clear and specific language: *I see you. I know this is work. You are not strange for finding it hard.*

A few thoughts for navigating this carefully:

- **Let the book do the work.** You do not need to name who in your room might be a Theo. The book names it. Students who recognize themselves will do so privately and in their own time. Your job is to hold the space open, not to identify anyone.
- **Be prepared for unexpected responses.** Some students will find the masking discussion clarifying in ways that might prompt disclosure — about themselves, about a sibling, about a parent. Have your school's support pathways ready, not because you are expecting a crisis, but because being prepared means you can respond well.
- **Watch for the student who's always fine.** In every classroom discussion of this book, there will probably be a student who says all the right things, contributes thoughtfully, and appears entirely unaffected. Notice that student. Not to call them out — but to let them know, in small ways, that they don't have to perform for you either.
- **The orange justice dance matters.** There is a moment near the end of the book where Theo does a silly dance — fully committed, in front of everyone — and stops managing for a minute. It is played for a laugh. It is also one of the most emotionally significant moments in the story. When you reach it with your class, let it land. Silliness can be courage. Sometimes the most important thing a person can do is stop being careful for a moment.
- **You may be a Theo too.** Teachers mask. Educators navigate enormous social demands daily, often while managing their own neurological differences, family complexity, and invisible weight. This book is not just for students. If something in it resonates for you — if you recognize the practiced scripts, the exhaustion, the love of new students who don't yet have conclusions about you — that is worth paying attention to.

Thank you for bringing this book into your classroom. The students who need it most may never tell you. But they will know you saw them.

Teacher Guide prepared for classroom use with Playing by Ear (In Our Own Words, Book Two) by Christina Carlsen.

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IN OUR OWN WORDS — BOOK TWO

Playing by Ear

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

Free Educator Resource • Grades 4–8

Discussion Questions

Playing by Ear (In Our Own Words — Book Two)

By Christina Carlsen

For classroom or book club use — Grades 4–8

These questions are designed to be open-ended and exploratory. There are no wrong answers. The goal is to think carefully, listen to each other, and notice things in the book — and in yourselves — that you might not have expected.

Before You Read

These questions activate prior knowledge and personal experience before diving into the story.

- If you have a sibling — or if you think about a pair of siblings you know — how do people usually describe them? Are one of them ever labeled “the easy one” or “the one who doesn’t need as much”? What do you think that label actually means for the person it gets attached to?
- Think about a time you practiced something before it happened — maybe rehearsed what you were going to say to someone, or imagined a conversation in your head. Why did you do that? Did it help? What does it say about you that you prepared that way?
- What do you think it means to learn something “by ear” — without being taught in a formal way? Can you think of something you know how to do that you figured out mostly by watching, listening, and repeating rather than following instructions?

Prologue & Chapters 1–4

“The Easier One,” the first day of fifth grade, practicing lunch table sentences, and Danny’s arrival

- In “The Easier One,” Theo says: “*The thing about being ‘the easier twin’ is everybody acts like it’s a compliment. Until you realize easy and invisible are cousins.*” What does he mean? Do you think being easy and being invisible are always connected — or can you be easy without being invisible?
- Theo spends time in his bedroom practicing exactly what he’ll say at the lunch table — “*Cool if I sit here? / What’d you get?*” — before he’s ever in the situation. Why does he do this, do you think? Does knowing that he rehearses change how you see him, or does it make him feel more familiar?
- Theo describes the first day of fifth grade and the way he manages other people’s impressions of him. What specific things does he do to seem “normal” or “easy”? Why do you think he works so hard at this? What does it cost him?

- When Danny (age 7) first appears, Theo notices that “*new people arrived without conclusions.*” What does he mean by that? Why might new people feel different or safer than people who’ve known you a long time?
- Theo thinks: “*If you kept people at the distance where they were still new, you never actually had them.*” What is he describing here? Have you ever kept someone at that distance on purpose? What made you do it — or stop doing it?
- Theo has Childhood Apraxia of Speech, which affects how his words come out — especially under stress. But most of his classmates don’t know this. How does he manage this at school? What kinds of situations feel most dangerous to him, and why?
- How does Theo feel about Jay, his school aide? What does Jay do — or not do — that Theo seems to appreciate? What does the way Theo talks about Jay tell us about what Theo actually needs from the people around him?

Chapters 5–8

Unified basketball, the game where Ellie comes in the wrong clothes and wearing her harness, Max walking onto the court, Theo saying the f-word and walking out, the conveyor belt, the “Easy Kids” conversation, the Mario movie

- When Eve says “He’s cool” about Danny joining Unified basketball — *without pausing* — Theo notices the no-pause. Why does that detail matter so much to him? What would it have meant if she had paused?
- Coach Daniels says: “*You take the shot. That’s your job.*” He’s talking about basketball, but Theo applies it to other things. What else do you think “take the shot” might mean in Theo’s life? Is there something in your own life where you’re waiting to take a shot?
- At the basketball game, Ellie arrives in the wrong clothes and with her harness on. Theo says: “*I get embarrassed sometimes. When they’re visible. And then I feel bad about feeling embarrassed because I love them.*” This is one of the most honest moments in the book. Why is it so hard to hold both of those feelings at once — loving someone and being embarrassed by them? Is Theo wrong to feel embarrassed?
- When Theo says the f-word in front of the whole gym and walks out, what do you think he’s actually reacting to? Is it just what happened in that moment, or has something been building for a long time? What does it take for someone who works as hard as Theo to finally lose control like that?
- After Theo walks out, Eve finds him in the hallway and holds his hand. She doesn’t say much. Why is that the right thing? What would have been the wrong thing to say or do in that moment?
- Theo describes the “conveyor belt” feeling — the sense that he keeps moving through situations without choosing any of them, just managing whatever comes next. Have you ever felt like you were on a conveyor belt in your own life? What would it feel like to step off?
- In the “Easy Kids” conversation, Theo reflects on who gets seen as easy and who gets seen as hard. What does he decide? Do you think schools and families actually treat kids differently based on who seems to need more? Is that fair?

- During the Mario movie, something small shifts between Theo and his family. What is it? Why do small moments like this — a movie, a couch, a laugh — sometimes matter more than big serious conversations?

Chapters 9–13

The rival town game, Mom’s reveal that she and Dad are also neurodivergent, the Monday after the f-word incident, Max teaching Theo the breathing exercise

- At the rival town game, Theo has to perform — on the court, in front of strangers, in a new gym. How does he prepare? What goes wrong? What, surprisingly, goes right? What does this game reveal about Theo that the home game couldn’t?
- When Mom tells Theo that she has anxiety, OCD, and ADHD — and that Dad is also neurodivergent — Theo’s understanding of his whole family shifts. She says: *“Everyone is worried about something. Everyone is carrying something the people around them can’t always see.”* How does this change how Theo sees his parents? Does it change how you see them?
- Mom’s reveal comes mid-book, not at the end. Why do you think the author put it there, rather than saving it for the climax? What does Theo do with this information before the book ends?
- The Monday after the f-word incident is one of Theo’s most dreaded moments — but Marcus covers for him. What does Marcus do, exactly? Why does this act of covering matter so much? What does it mean to have someone cover for you when you’ve made a mistake in public?
- Marcus is described as reliable — not flashy, not dramatic, just reliably there. Theo thinks about the difference between a friend who covers for you and a friend who makes you feel seen. Can someone be both? Does Marcus become both by the end?
- Max teaches Theo his breathing exercise and says *“Good”* and *“I can do it.”* This is a reversal — usually Theo is the one holding Max’s calm. What does this moment mean for both brothers? Why is it significant that it’s Max who teaches, not Theo who learns from an adult?
- Theo has been masking all year — performing “easy” for everyone around him. When does he first let the mask slip a little, and with whom? What makes that person or moment feel safe enough?
- Theo pieces together the sentence on Ms. Patrice’s whiteboard: *“My family. Visible. Tired of managing. Scared of what people see.”* This takes him a long time. Why? Is this a hard sentence to write because of his speech, or because of what it means?

Chapters 14–18 & Epilogue

Alex in the courtyard, Eve's hair, the dance and the orange justice, the ending on the doorstep

- Alex — the former friend who laughed at Theo during the playground incident — is now being bullied himself. Theo has to decide what to do. What does he do? What would you have done? Does what happened between them before change what Theo owes Alex now?
- At the dance, Theo does the orange justice — fully committed, without managing how it looks. What makes this moment possible? What had to happen across the whole book before Theo could do something like this without holding back?
- Dad asks Theo “*You want to go further?*” and they keep walking. This is a quiet ending to the book, but it feels enormous. What are they walking toward, do you think — literally and figuratively? What has changed between Theo and his dad by this point?
- The book closes with Theo saying “*I love you too*” on the doorstep — something he’s never said first. Theo thinks: “*I wanted this family, exactly as it was, with a little more room for all of himself in it.*” What does “room for all of himself” mean? What did Theo have to give up — or learn — to find that room?

Questions may be used freely for classroom and book club purposes.

IN OUR OWN WORDS — BOOK TWO

Playing by Ear

READING GROUP GUIDE

Free Educator Resource · Grades 4–8

Reading Group Guide

***Playing by Ear* (In Our Own Words — Book Two)**

By Christina Carlsen

For parent-led book clubs, homeschool groups, and community reading circles

About This Book

Most stories about disability — and most stories about families navigating disability — follow the child who needs the most support. *Playing by Ear* does something different. It follows Theo, the twin who doesn't. Theo is eleven, funny, social, good at school — and, as far as most people can tell, completely fine. His twin brother Max has autism and uses a communication device. His little sister Ellie is autistic and nonverbal. His parents are managing, always managing. And Theo? Theo is easy. He has always been easy.

But *Playing by Ear* is a book about what easy actually costs. Theo has Childhood Apraxia of Speech — a neurological condition that affects his ability to produce words reliably, especially under stress — and he is autistic himself, though this is not obvious to anyone around him. What is obvious is his warmth, his humor, his usefulness. What is invisible is the relentless work behind all of it: the conversations practiced alone in his bedroom, the constant reading of rooms, the tracking of every social threat, the performance of being the one who doesn't need anything extra. Theo has made himself so easy that he has nearly disappeared.

This is a book about a boy learning to take up space. It is also a book about families — the way neurodivergence travels through generations in different forms, the way love and embarrassment can coexist without canceling each other out, and the way one friendship (real, honest, unadorned) can begin to undo years of careful self-erasure. It is funny and quiet and sneakily devastating, and it will land differently for every reader in the room — which is exactly the point.

A Note to Group Facilitators

Playing by Ear is a book for kids ages 9–13, but we want to be honest with you: it may hit the adults in your group harder than the children. The themes of masking, invisible labor, and being the family member who is assumed to be fine resonate deeply with readers who have been the “easy” child, the “capable” sibling, the parent who manages quietly, or the person who has only recently begun to understand their own neurodivergent traits. Don't be surprised if a discussion question about Theo's lunch-table rehearsals opens a door for a parent in the room.

This is a good thing. One of the gifts of this book is that it creates a shared language for experiences that are often hard to name. If an adult in your group gets unexpectedly emotional, that's the book doing its job.

A few things to keep in mind as you facilitate:

- **Let kids lead.** The book is told in an eleven-year-old's voice, and young readers often notice things adults miss. Make space for their observations before offering your own.
- **Don't press.** Some of the themes here — embarrassment about a family member, feeling invisible, hiding something about yourself — are tender. Invite, don't require.
- **"Me too" is enough.** As Eve demonstrates in the book, sometimes the most powerful response to someone's honesty is simple acknowledgment. You don't have to fix it or explain it. "Me too" is a full sentence.
- **It's okay not to finish the questions.** Pick the ones that feel alive for your group. A single question that sparks twenty minutes of real conversation is worth more than ten questions answered briefly.

Discussion Questions

These questions are designed so that a ten-year-old and an adult can both contribute meaningfully. Start with the kids.

- Theo calls himself "the easier twin." What do you think that means? Is being easy always a good thing? Can you think of a time when being easy for someone else might cost you something?
- Theo practices conversations in his bedroom before he has them — he writes scripts for things like sitting down at the lunch table. Does knowing this change how you think about him? Have you ever done something like this — rehearsed something in your head before it happened?
- Eve tells Theo she gets nervous too — and instead of explaining or minimizing it, she just says "*Me too.*" Why is that such a powerful thing to say? When is "me too" more useful than advice?
- Theo notices that new people "*arrived without conclusions.*" What does he mean? Is there freedom in being new to someone? Is there also a loneliness to it?
- Theo loves his family — and he's also embarrassed by them sometimes. He says he feels bad for feeling embarrassed because he loves them. Is it possible to hold both of those feelings at the same time? Is the embarrassment a sign that something is wrong, or is it just human?
- Coach Daniels tells Theo: "*You take the shot. That's your job.*" What do you think "your job" means, for each person in your group? What is something you've been avoiding taking a shot at?
- When Mom reveals that she has anxiety, OCD, and ADHD — and that Dad is also neurodivergent — Theo understands his family differently. She says: "*Every one is carrying something the people around them can't always see.*" What does your family carry that isn't always visible to others?
- Jay is Theo's school aide. He has a gift for being present without making Theo feel watched or labeled. What does Jay do that makes him different from bad aides Theo has had before? What qualities would you want in someone whose job was to support you?
- Marcus covers for Theo on the Monday after the worst moment of Theo's year. What does it mean to have someone cover for you when you've made a mistake in public? Has anyone ever done that for you — or have you done it for someone else?
- Theo describes the exhaustion of masking — performing "easy" all day, every day. Where in your life do you wear a mask? Is there a difference between a mask and just being polite or professional?

- By the end of the book, Theo says: *“Belonging isn’t a place you find once. It’s something you keep choosing.”* What does he mean? Do you agree? Where do you keep choosing to belong?
- Eve gives Theo infinity rings and says *“They’re for reminders.”* What do you think she means? What would you want a reminder of — something you need to remember about yourself when things get hard?
- At the basketball game, Theo’s family arrives — Ellie in the wrong clothes, harness on, visible in the way that Theo has spent years managing. Then Max walks onto the court. What does Theo do? What does he wish he could do? How do you hold love and overwhelm at the same time?
- The dance is the first time Theo does something completely — the orange justice, fully committed, without managing how it looks. What made that moment possible? What had to change, or accumulate, across the whole book for Theo to be able to do that?
- The book ends with Theo and his dad walking together, and his dad asking: *“You want to go further?”* And they keep walking. What do you think that moment means? What is Theo walking toward?

Things to Do Together

These activities work best when your group does them together — not as homework, but as a shared experience during your meeting.

- **Practice a Conversation Out Loud:** Choose a situation where you might feel nervous — meeting someone new, asking for help, making a phone call. Write out what you might say, word by word, the way Theo does. Then actually say it out loud to the group. Debrief: Did saying it out loud feel different from just thinking it? Did you realize you already knew how to do it?
- **The “New People” List:** Theo loves how new people arrive without conclusions — they haven’t decided who you are yet. Each person in the group writes down one thing they wish new people in their lives could know about them right away — something that often gets missed or misread. Share (or don’t — keeping it is fine too).
- **Infinity Rings:** Eve gives Theo rings as reminders. Each person in the group gets a small slip of paper and writes one thing they want to remember about themselves — a true thing, a kind thing, a fierce thing. Fold it up and put it somewhere you’ll find it later.
- **The Invisible Backpack:** Theo carries a lot of invisible things: managing his family’s visibility in public, practicing conversations, tracking threats, performing easy. Each person draws or lists what’s in their invisible backpack right now — things they’re carrying that other people might not see. You don’t have to share. But if you want to, you can.
- **“Me Too”:** One person shares something small and true — something they feel nervous about, something they find hard, something they wish they didn’t have to do. The rest of the group responds only with: *“Me too”* (if true) or silence (if not). No advice. No fixing. No “well, have you tried...” Just witnessing. See how it feels.

What Theo Taught Us

Before you close your books, take a few minutes — quietly or together — to sit with these questions.

- Theo spent most of his life making himself easy. Is there any way you’ve done this too — made yourself smaller or less complicated for someone else? What would it look like to take up a little more space?
- Is there someone in your life who might be the “easy one” — the person everyone assumes is fine? What would it mean to actually ask how they are?
- Theo says: *“I wanted this family, exactly as it was, with a little more room for all of himself in it.”* What does that sentence mean to you, in your own life?
- What are you going to carry out of this book?

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IN OUR OWN WORDS — BOOK TWO

Playing by Ear

ACTIVITY SHEETS

Free Educator Resource · Grades 4–8

Activity Sheets

Playing by Ear (In Our Own Words — Book Two)

By Christina Carlsen

Five student activities — Grades 4–8

Activity 1: The List

Grade Level: 4–8

Works best: Independently or with a partner

What You'll Need

- This sheet
- A pencil or pen
- About 20 minutes

Background

In *Playing by Ear*, Theo practices what he's going to say before he says it. Before he sits down at the lunch table, he rehearses exact sentences in his bedroom:

"Cool if I sit here? / What'd you get?"

He knows what he'll say if someone says yes. He knows what he'll say if someone says no. He has a script — not because he's being fake, but because having the words ready makes the moment feel less dangerous.

Instructions

Step 1. Think of a situation where starting a conversation feels hard or uncertain. It could be: sitting down at a new lunch table, starting a conversation at a party or event where you don't know many people, joining a group that's already working together, talking to someone you admire but don't know well, or asking for help from an adult you don't know. Pick one situation and write it here:

My situation: _____

Step 2. Now write five things you could say to start a conversation in that situation. They don't have to be clever — they just have to be real. Write them like Theo does: exactly what you'd say, word for word.

1. _____ 2. _____ 3. _____ 4. _____ 5. _____

Step 3. Pick your best one. Say it out loud, to yourself or to a partner. (Yes, actually say it. Out loud.)

Step 4. If you're working with a partner, take turns: one person starts the conversation with their opener, the other person responds naturally. See what happens.

Reflection Questions

- Did writing these sentences help, or did they feel awkward? What was hard about it?
- When you said your best line out loud, did it feel different than just thinking it? Why might that be?
- Theo practices because he has a speech difference that makes unexpected words harder — but lots of people rehearse conversations, even people without any speech difference. What does it say about a person that they prepare this way? Is it a strength, a coping strategy, both, or something else?

Activity 2: Playing by Ear

Grade Level: 4–8

Works best: Independently, then share with a small group

What You'll Need

- This sheet
- A pencil or pen
- About 25–30 minutes

Background

Theo plays drums and keyboard — and he learned mostly by ear. He didn't read sheet music first. He listened. He watched. He tried things until they sounded right. He figured it out from the inside.

“Playing by ear” is a phrase musicians use for learning music without written notation — just by listening and repeating. But the idea applies to a lot more than music. Some of the best things people know, they learned by ear: by watching someone else, by practicing in private, by making mistakes and adjusting.

Instructions

Step 1. Think of something you know how to do that you learned without being formally taught. It could be a game, a skill, a social skill, an art form, or a hobby. Write what it is here:

I learned _____ mostly by ear.

Step 2. Now write a step-by-step guide for how someone else could learn this the same way you did. Be specific. What did you watch? What did you try first? What went wrong and what fixed it?

My “by ear” how-to guide: Step 1: _____ Step 2: _____ Step 3: _____ Step 4: _____ Step 5: _____

Step 3. Optional — If you're in a group, share your how-to guide with one other person. Can they follow it?

Reflection Questions

- Was it hard to explain something you learned intuitively? What made it difficult to put into words?
- Is there a difference between knowing how to do something and knowing how to explain it? What does that gap tell you?
- Theo's whole identity is wrapped up in learning by ear — music, social situations, family dynamics. What does it mean to learn something by heart rather than by rule?

Activity 3: The Two Faces

Grade Level: 4–8

Works best: Independently or with a partner

What You'll Need

- This sheet
- A pencil or pen
- About 30 minutes

Background

In *Playing by Ear*, Theo notices that Mrs. Crane has two faces — one for his mom (polite but tight, managing), and a different one for the school bus (relaxed, laughing). Same person. Different settings. Different version of herself. Theo is an expert at noticing this, partly because he does it himself. He has a face for school, a face for home, a face for strangers, a face for new people, a face for old friends. Most people do — though not everyone realizes it.

Instructions

Step 1. Think of a real or fictional person (it can be you, someone you know, a character from a book or show) who acts differently in two different settings.

My character or person: _____

Step 2. Write two short scenes — about a paragraph each — showing the same person in two different situations. Use details: what do they say? How do they hold their body? What do they do with their hands? What do they choose not to say?

Scene 1 — Setting: _____ (*Write your scene here*) *Scene 2 — Setting:* _____ (*Write your scene here*)

Step 3. Read both scenes back. Circle or underline one detail in each scene that feels most true to this person.

Reflection Questions

- Why do you think people act differently in different settings? Is it always dishonest — or can it be something else?
- Theo works incredibly hard to have only one public face: the easy, capable, funny one. What would happen if his school face and his home face got mixed up? What does that possibility feel like to him?
- Are there settings where you are most yourself? Settings where you are least yourself? What's the difference between them?

Activity 4: Invisible Load

Grade Level: 4–8

Works best: Independently (this one can be private)

What You'll Need

- This sheet
- Pencil, pen, or colored pencils
- About 20–30 minutes

Background

All year, Theo carries things that no one can see:

- The awareness of where Ellie is in a crowd
- The tracking of whether Max is about to have a hard moment
- The practiced conversations he's run through in his room
- The memory of the playground incident
- The weight of always being the one who is fine
- The secret that he is not, actually, always fine

None of this is visible. He carries it in his body, in his attention, in his energy. It's called an invisible load — the things we carry that don't show up on the outside. Everyone has one.

Instructions

Step 1. In the space below (or on a separate piece of paper), draw the outline of a large backpack. It can be simple — just a shape.

(Draw your backpack here, or on a separate page.)

Step 2. Inside the backpack, write or draw the things you carry that other people might not see. These might include: worries about someone you love, something you're pretending is fine when it isn't, a memory that keeps coming back, a responsibility you carry that no one assigned you, something you're hoping for but haven't told anyone, or a feeling you've been managing for a long time. You don't have to share this. It's yours.

Step 3. When you're done, look at what you put in the backpack. Is it heavier or lighter than you expected?

Reflection Questions

- Were there things you put in the backpack that surprised you — things you didn't realize you were carrying until you tried to draw them?
- Theo never tells anyone about his invisible load — until he starts to, very slowly, with Eve and Ms. Patrice. What makes it hard to let someone else see what you're carrying? What would make it easier?
- Is carrying invisible things always a burden — or can some of it be a strength? What's the difference?

Note: This activity is about personal reflection. You are never required to share what you put in your backpack. If something in your backpack feels too heavy to carry alone, that's worth telling a trusted adult.

Activity 5: The Orange Justice Moment

Grade Level: 4–8

Works best: Independently, then share (optional)

What You'll Need

- This sheet
- A pencil or pen
- About 25–30 minutes

Background

At the school dance near the end of *Playing by Ear*, Theo does the orange justice — a dance move — fully committed. He doesn't hold back. He doesn't watch himself. He doesn't manage how it looks. This is a huge moment. Not because of the dance move, but because of what it costs Theo to stop managing. All year, he has been monitoring himself — performing easy, tracking reactions, keeping people at the distance where they're still new. The orange justice isn't about dancing. It's about doing something completely, without protecting yourself from how it looks. We all have moments like this. Or moments where we could have — and didn't.

Instructions

Step 1. Think of a moment — real or imagined — when you did something (or could do something) completely: without holding back, without watching yourself, without managing how it came across. Write about that moment here. Be specific: where were you? What happened right before? What did it feel like to stop holding back?

(Write your moment here)

Step 2. Now write about what made it possible. Something had to happen — inside you or around you — that made it okay to go all the way. What was it?

(Write here)

Step 3. Optional — If you're working with a group, share your moment. You don't have to share the specific details — you can describe the feeling instead.

Reflection Questions

- What's the difference between being reckless and being fully committed? How did Theo know the dance was the right moment?
- Is there something in your life you've been doing halfway — holding back a little, just in case? What would it mean to do it fully?
- Theo's orange justice moment came at the end of a whole year of small changes. What had to happen first? What does that say about how people change?

Activity sheets may be reproduced freely for classroom and book club use.

IN OUR OWN WORDS — BOOK TWO

Playing by Ear

EXTENSION ACTIVITIES

Free Educator Resource · Grades 4–8

Extension Activities

Playing by Ear (In Our Own Words — Book Two)

By Christina Carlsen

Eight optional enrichment activities for students who want to go deeper — Grades 4–8

These activities are a menu, not an assignment. Choose one that calls to you — something you’re genuinely curious about, something that connects to your own experience, or something that surprised you in the book. Do it your way.

1. CAS Research Project

Difficulty: Medium

Description:

Childhood Apraxia of Speech (CAS) is the neurological condition that affects Theo’s speech — it’s not a stutter, it’s not a language delay, and it’s not what most people picture when they think of a speech difference. It affects the brain’s ability to coordinate the precise movements needed to produce sounds reliably, especially under stress or when words are new. Research what CAS actually is: how it’s diagnosed, how it’s different from other speech differences (stuttering, dysarthria, language delay), and what kinds of speech therapy are most effective. If possible, find a speech therapist, SLP student, or person with CAS who would be willing to answer a few questions — even by email.

What you’ll create:

A research report, presentation, or illustrated fact sheet explaining CAS for an audience of kids your age who have never heard of it. Your goal: make it real, not clinical. Include at least one first-person account or quote from someone with CAS, if you can find one.

2. Masking — What and Why

Difficulty: Medium

Description:

“Masking” is a term used most often in autistic communities to describe the conscious or unconscious process of suppressing natural behaviors and mimicking neurotypical ones — in order to fit in, avoid judgment, or stay safe. Theo is an expert masker: he practices conversations, monitors his own reactions, and performs “easy” all day every day. But masking isn’t only an autistic experience — many people mask for many reasons. Research what masking means in the context of autism and neurodivergence specifically: who masks most, what it costs over time (research suggests it is connected to burnout and mental health challenges), and why people do it even

when it's exhausting. Consider: what would it mean for a school or community to create conditions where masking is less necessary?

What you'll create:

A presentation, infographic, video, or essay explaining masking to someone who has never encountered the concept. Include both the research and your own thinking: do you see masking anywhere in your own life or community?

3. Unified Sports — Research and Proposal

Difficulty: Medium to Challenging

Description:

Coach Daniels runs a Unified basketball team — a model where students with and without disabilities play together on the same team, not on separate teams that occasionally meet. This is based on the real Unified Sports model developed by Special Olympics. Research how Unified Sports works: its origins, the structure of teams, how it differs from peer-support programs or inclusion models in PE class, and what research shows about its social and academic benefits for all players involved. Then find out: does your school or community have a Unified team? If not, what would it take to start one? Who would you need to talk to?

What you'll create:

A research report plus a one-page proposal addressed to a real person (a principal, athletic director, or community organization) explaining why a Unified team would benefit your school or community. Make it specific and persuasive.

4. Design the Perfect Aide

Difficulty: Easy to Medium

Description:

Jay is Theo's school aide, and he is exceptional — not because he does the most, but because he does exactly the right amount. He is present without hovering. He is helpful without labeling. He creates space without disappearing. He reads Theo's signals. He never makes Theo feel watched or managed. He doesn't talk about Theo in front of Theo as if Theo isn't there. In contrast, there are aides described across both books in this series who get it wrong in different ways — too much, too little, too loud about it. Using what you've observed about Jay (and about what goes wrong with less effective aides), design a job description for the ideal school support aide.

What you'll create:

A formal job description (as if posted on a school district's website) that includes: the role's purpose, essential qualities (not just skills — qualities), what the aide should do, what they should never do, and how success would be measured. Include a section called “What Students Say Matters” — what would students like Theo want an aide to understand from the start?

5. Two Perspectives on the Same Moment

Difficulty: Medium to Challenging

Description:

Playing by Ear is told entirely from Theo's perspective — we only ever see what Theo notices, interprets, and chooses to tell us. But every scene has other people in it who are experiencing the same moment completely differently. Choose one scene from the book and rewrite it from another character's point of view. Good options include: the hallway ambush from Ms. Patrice's perspective (what was she hoping would happen?), the rival town basketball game from Eve's perspective (what does she notice about Theo that Theo doesn't notice about himself?), the basketball game from Mom's perspective (watching both Theo and Ellie and Max at once), or the Monday-after-the-incident from Marcus's perspective (why did he cover for Theo, and what did it cost him?).

What you'll create:

A scene of at least 400 words written in first-person from a character other than Theo. It must cover the same events as the original scene but reveal things about that character's inner life that Theo couldn't have known. Pay close attention to voice — the way this character thinks and speaks should feel different from Theo.

6. The Inheritance Map

Difficulty: Easy to Medium

Description:

One of the quieter revelations of *Playing by Ear* is that neurodivergence isn't something that arrived with Max and Ellie — it runs through the family in different forms, in different generations, expressing differently in every person. Mom has anxiety, OCD, and ADHD. Dad has his own neurodivergent traits that he manages through routines and structure. Grandpa sang to Ellie — and Ellie's three-note hum came from him. Theo is autistic and has CAS. Max is autistic. Ellie is autistic and nonverbal. Different expressions of the same underlying fabric. Create a “family trait map” that traces how qualities, challenges, strengths, and ways of being move through a family — not as a medical tree, but as a living web of connection.

What you'll create:

A visual map (hand-drawn or digital) of Theo's family — or a family from another book, show, or your own life — that traces visible and invisible traits across people and generations. Include not just challenges but strengths: things like musical ability, pattern recognition, deep loyalty, humor, intensity. Add a written reflection (one paragraph minimum) about what you noticed while making it.

7. Being the “Easy One” — An Essay or Podcast

Difficulty: Challenging

Description:

Theo has spent his life being the sibling — and the child — who is assumed to be fine. He is the easy one. He is the one who doesn't need anything extra. And the book argues, quietly but clearly, that this assumption has a cost: it makes invisible the real complexity of his inner life, his real needs, and his real struggle. This theme — the invisible experience of the sibling or child who isn't “the identified one” — is not unique to families navigating disability. Explore it. Write a personal essay or record a short podcast episode (5–8 minutes) examining what it means to have invisible struggles in a family or community where someone else's needs are more visible. Draw on the book, on research (siblings of children with disabilities is a studied area), and — if you're willing — on your own experience.

What you'll create:

A personal essay of at least 500 words, or an audio recording of 5–8 minutes. This should not just summarize the book's themes — it should think through them, ask real questions, and arrive somewhere the author didn't necessarily take you.

8. Before the Story — A Prequel Scene

Difficulty: Challenging

Description:

Playing by Ear begins at the start of Theo's fifth-grade year — but Theo has been Theo for eleven years before the book opens. He has been masking since long before he had a word for it. He was there the day Max was separated onto a different bus. He was there through every difficult public moment with Ellie. He has been practicing conversations in his bedroom for years. Write a prequel scene: a moment from Theo's fourth-grade year, or from the summer before fifth grade, or from the day Max was moved to a different classroom or bus. The scene should be told entirely in Theo's voice — the same voice established in the novel — but it should show us something about who he was before the events of this book. It should feel like a scene that could have appeared in *Playing by Ear* but didn't.

What you'll create:

A scene of at least 500 words in Theo's first-person voice. Before you write, spend some time with Theo's voice in the book: his humor, his precision, his habit of noticing small things, the way he holds his feelings at one remove. Your scene should feel like *him* — not like a summary of his backstory.

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